

CHANGE

1

CHANGE ONE MIND. CHANGE ONE LIFE.

Beyond the Voucher

What It Actually Takes to Keep Foster Youth Housed



A voucher may open the door, but **support services** help young people get there — and **stay** there.



75+ documented touchpoints during **one phase** of stabilization before move-in.

YOUTH NEED CONTINUED SUPPORT AFTER THEY ARE HOUSED.

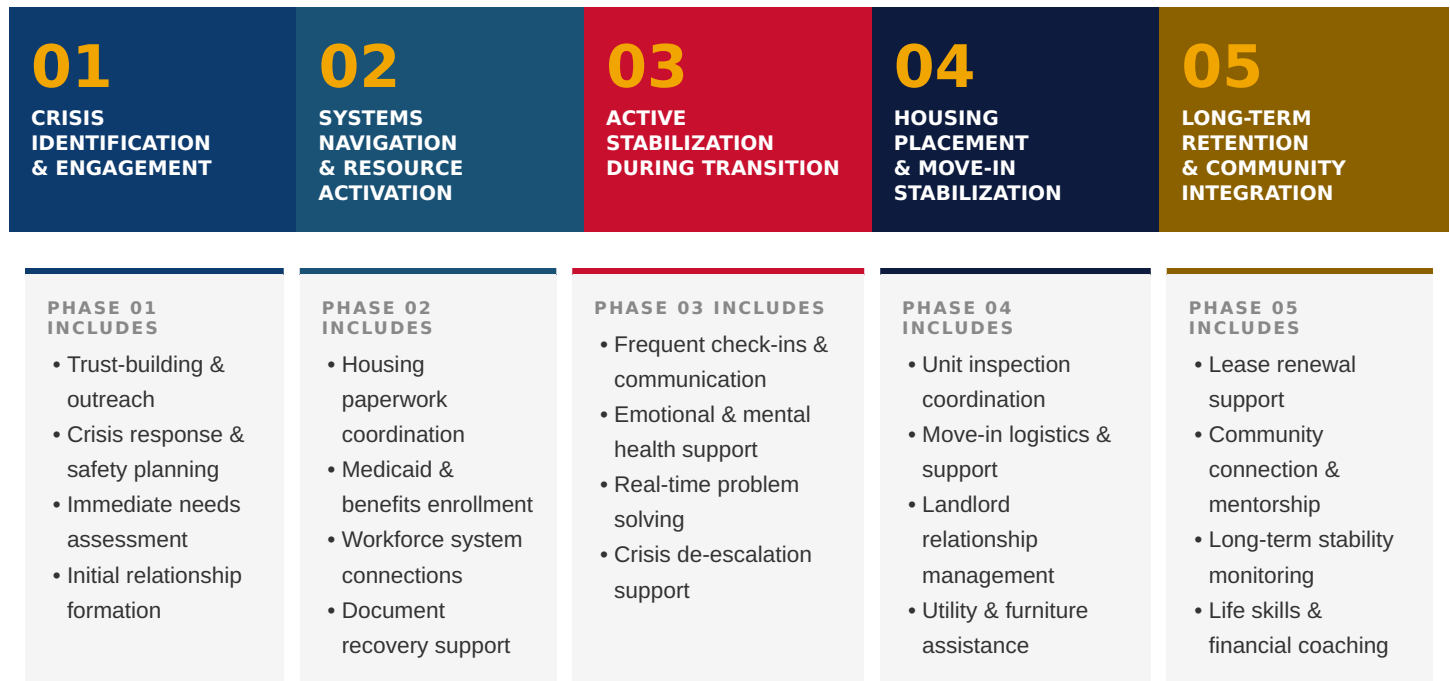


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THE CHANGE 1 FRAMEWORK

The Change 1 Stabilization Continuum™

Housing stability for transition-age youth is not achieved through a single intervention. It requires coordinated, relationship-centered stabilization across multiple phases — each building on the last, none of which can be skipped.

**MOVE-IN IS NOT THE FINISH LINE.**

Stabilization is an ongoing process. Each phase requires dedicated staff time, relational investment, and coordinated resources that go far beyond what a voucher alone can provide.

THIS IS NOT LINEAR. THIS IS RELATIONAL.

Young people move through these phases at different speeds, often cycling back. Success requires a consistent, trusted support person who meets them where they are — every time.

A voucher may open the door — but **support services** help young people get there, and **stay there**.

What Stabilization Actually Looks Like

A documented case study showing the labor required to help one young person get housed — and why it matters for policy.

"Marcus"

Age: 20

Status: Aging out of foster care

Prior Housing: Couch surfing

Voucher: FYI Voucher (HUD)

Timeline: 5 months to move-in

Touchpoints Before Move-In: **75+**

Marcus aged out of the Texas foster care system at 18 and spent nearly two years navigating unstable housing — couch surfing, brief shelter stays, and periods of literal homelessness. When Change 1 engaged him, he had a Foster Youth Initiative (FYI) voucher in hand. **The voucher was the first step, not the solution.**

What followed was five months of intensive, coordinated support before Marcus moved into a unit. That work required a dedicated staff member walking with Marcus through each barrier — one by one, day by day.

This is not an exceptional story. This is what stabilization looks like for transition-age youth who have experienced the foster care system.

YOUTH STABILIZATION TIMELINE — FROM ENGAGEMENT TO MOVE-IN

PHASE 1 — MONTH 1

Initial Engagement & Trust Building

Multiple outreach contacts, missed appointments, patient relationship building. Staff remained consistent.

PHASE 2 — MONTH 1-2

Voucher Activation & Document Recovery

Birth certificate lost. State ID expired. Social security card unavailable. Each document required separate appointments and follow-up.

PHASE 2 — MONTH 2

Housing Search — First Barriers Hit

Two landlords declined. One unit failed inspection. Staff coordinated voucher extension. Marcus nearly gave up.

PHASE 3 — MONTH 2-3

Crisis Intervention — Placement Disrupted

Marcus lost his temporary housing. Emergency placement coordinated. Mental health referral initiated. Staff on call over a weekend.

PHASE 3 — MONTH 3-4

Benefits Navigation & Income Verification

Medicaid lapse required re-enrollment. SSI application submitted. Each agency required separate contact and documentation.

PHASE 4 — MONTH 4

Approved Unit Found — Inspection Coordination

First unit failed inspection. Landlord communication facilitated by staff. Second re-inspection scheduled and passed.

PHASE 4 — MONTH 4-5

Move-In Preparation & Stabilization

Utility setup, furniture coordination, lease review, move-in day accompanied by Change 1 staff. 75th+ touchpoint documented.

PHASE 5 — ONGOING

Post-Move-In Retention Support Begins

Regular check-ins continue. Lease renewal ahead. Community connection in progress. The work does not end at move-in.

75+

Documented staff touchpoints before a single move-in

Calls, appointments, home visits, coordination meetings, crisis responses, document requests, and follow-up contacts for one young person — during one phase of stabilization. This does not include the ongoing retention support required after housing placement. This is the infrastructure behind every successful housing outcome.

What Support Services Actually Include

Support services are not supplemental. They are the mechanism through which a voucher becomes a home.

When policymakers discuss housing for transition-age youth, the conversation often starts and stops at voucher access. But a voucher is a financial instrument — it does not find an apartment, negotiate with a landlord, navigate a housing inspection, resolve a Medicaid lapse, or answer the phone at 10pm during a crisis. Support services do. Below is what that actually looks like.

HOUSING NAVIGATION

Active search for units that accept vouchers. Coordinating showings, application support, income verification, and advocating for youth with reluctant landlords. This alone can take weeks to months.

SYSTEMS NAVIGATION

Helping youth access and maintain Medicaid, SNAP, SSI/SSDI, workforce services, and housing authority requirements — each system with its own processes, deadlines, and documentation demands.

LANDLORD COORDINATION

Building relationships with landlords willing to accept voucher holders. Facilitating inspections, handling disputes, and serving as a trusted liaison throughout the tenancy.

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT & MENTORSHIP

A consistent, trusted relationship through setbacks, crises, and wins. For youth who aged out of foster care, this is often the first stable relationship they have known.

CRISIS RESPONSE

Real-time intervention when instability escalates — lost placement, mental health crisis, lease violation threat. Crisis response prevents exits from housing before they happen.

TRANSPORTATION ASSISTANCE

Getting to appointments, unit showings, agency offices, and inspections. Without transportation support, housing timelines collapse for youth with no reliable transit access.

WORKFORCE SUPPORT

Employment readiness, job placement coordination, income documentation — income stability is inseparable from housing stability for youth navigating both simultaneously.

HEALTHCARE COORDINATION

Medicaid enrollment, mental health referrals, substance use support coordination, and ensuring health needs are not a barrier to housing retention.

LONG-TERM RETENTION SUPPORT

Lease renewal assistance, conflict resolution, financial coaching, and continued check-ins to prevent eviction and maintain stability beyond the first year.

These services are not optional add-ons. They are the operational infrastructure that transforms housing access into housing stability. Without dedicated funding for community-based organizations to provide these services, vouchers go unused, placements fall apart, and youth cycle back into homelessness — at greater cost to the system and greater harm to themselves.

The Hidden Labor of Youth Housing Stabilization

Behind every placement is a significant volume of coordinated staff work that rarely appears in outcome reports — but makes those outcomes possible.

Housing outcome data typically shows one metric: housed or not housed. What it does not show is the volume of labor required to produce that outcome. Each young person's journey involves dozens to hundreds of individual staff actions. This work is often invisible to funders and policymakers, yet it is precisely this labor that determines whether a young person stays housed.

75+

Documented touchpoints before move-in for one youth

5+

Months of active engagement before placement

3–8

Average agencies coordinated per young person

∞

Touchpoints required after move-in for long-term stability

PRE-PLACEMENT LABOR	ACTIVE TRANSITION LABOR	POST-PLACEMENT RETENTION LABOR
Initial outreach & repeated engagement attempts	Crisis response calls and emergency coordination	Regular wellness and retention check-ins
Trust-building visits and relationship development	Mental health referral and follow-through	Lease violation prevention and early intervention
Needs assessment and goal setting	Workforce program enrollment and coordination	Neighbor and landlord dispute resolution
Document recovery (ID, SS card, birth certificate)	Benefits verification for housing eligibility	Financial coaching and rent management support
Housing application submission and follow-up	Transportation assistance to appointments	Lease renewal planning and negotiation
Voucher briefing coordination with housing authority	Lease signing support and review with youth	Ongoing mental health connection maintenance
Housing search support and unit identification	Move-in day assistance and setup coordination	Community connection and social integration
Landlord outreach and relationship building	Utility connection and initial setup support	Employment stability monitoring and support
Inspection coordination and re-inspection follow-up	Furniture and household goods coordination	Life skills development and coaching
Medicaid/SNAP enrollment or reinstatement	Landlord communication throughout transition	Crisis response — ongoing, as needed

Why this matters for policy: Community-based organizations like Change 1 absorb this labor on behalf of public systems — often without dedicated, sustainable funding streams that reflect the true cost. When CBOs are underfunded or excluded from policy conversations, this work disappears — and so do the outcomes. Funding policy must account for the full cost of stabilization, not just the cost of a voucher.

Policy Recommendations

The following recommendations reflect Change 1's experience on the ground and our commitment to building systems that actually work for transition-age youth.

Vouchers are necessary. But they are not sufficient. These policy recommendations reflect what it actually takes to produce stable housing outcomes for youth aging out of foster care — informed by direct practice, documented case data, and deep community expertise.

1

FUNDING

FUND SUPPORT SERVICES AS A REQUIRED COMPANION TO FYI VOUCHERS

Every FYI voucher issued should be accompanied by a dedicated funding allocation for housing navigation and stabilization services. Vouchers without support infrastructure have significantly lower placement and retention rates. Federal and state appropriations must account for the full cost of stabilization — not just the subsidy itself.

2

VOUCHER ACCESS

INCREASE FYI VOUCHER AVAILABILITY AND EXTEND SEARCH TIMELINES

Current voucher search timelines are insufficient for the realities facing youth with no rental history and no credit. Search period extensions and protections from arbitrary expiration are essential. Supply of vouchers must also be increased to meet documented need.

3

SYSTEMS

REQUIRE CROSS-AGENCY COORDINATION FOR TRANSITION-AGE YOUTH

Housing stability requires coordination across DFPS, housing authorities, Medicaid, workforce systems, and community-based providers. A coordinated case management structure with clear data-sharing agreements and joint accountability must be codified in policy — not left to informal relationships.

4

CBOS & PROVIDERS

CREATE SUSTAINABLE FUNDING PATHWAYS FOR COMMUNITY-BASED ORGANIZATIONS

CBOs provide the relational, on-the-ground stabilization labor that government systems cannot replicate. Funding models must reflect the actual cost of this work. Competitive grant cycles and short contract periods undermine the continuity that stabilization requires.

5

DATA & ACCOUNTABILITY

TRACK RETENTION — NOT JUST PLACEMENT — AS THE PRIMARY HOUSING METRIC

Current reporting rewards placement. Retention-based accountability measures — tracking housing stability at 6, 12, and 24 months — tied to funding would shift incentives toward the full stabilization model that produces lasting outcomes rather than temporary placements.

6

LANDLORD ENGAGEMENT

INVEST IN LANDLORD INCENTIVE AND RISK MITIGATION PROGRAMS

Landlord risk mitigation funds — covering damage deposits, minor repairs, and vacancy losses — reduce hesitation and expand voucher-accepting units. This is a high-impact, low-cost policy lever that directly increases placement rates.

Why Community-Based Organizations Must Be Included and Funded

Government systems are essential — but they cannot replicate what community-based organizations do at the ground level.

The stabilization work described in this brief — the relationship-building, crisis response, landlord coordination, systems navigation, and ongoing retention support — is largely carried out by community-based organizations operating on the margins of public funding. Change 1 exists in that space. So do dozens of other CBOs across Texas providing this essential infrastructure without sustainable investment. This must change.

WHAT CBOS PROVIDE THAT SYSTEMS CANNOT	THE FUNDING GAP CBOS FACE	WHAT POLICYMAKERS CAN DO
Community-based organizations carry a distinct capacity that cannot be replicated by government agencies: • Trusted relationships built over time in community • Cultural competency and lived-experience alignment • Flexibility to respond outside office hours and system constraints • Relational, trauma-informed engagement capacity • Ability to coordinate informally across agencies • Long-term continuity with youth beyond service periods	Despite their essential role, CBOs commonly face: • Short-term grant funding with high administrative burden • Outcome metrics that don't capture relational labor • Exclusion from government contracting pipelines • Under-resourced staff managing unsustainable caseloads • No dedicated funding streams for retention services • Forced competition with larger organizations for limited resources	To meaningfully include and fund CBOs: • Multi-year contracts enabling staffing and program continuity • Funding models tied to retention, not just placement • Dedicated CBO set-asides in housing stabilization funding • Reduced administrative burden for smaller community providers • Formal CBO inclusion in housing system planning tables • Investment in CBO capacity-building and infrastructure

ABOUT CHANGE 1

Change 1 is an Austin, Texas-based nonprofit dedicated to transforming the lives of foster-care-impacted youth. With deep roots in the community and a model built on relationship-centered, trauma-informed practice, Change 1 has walked alongside transition-age youth navigating housing instability, system barriers, and the transition out of foster care. Our experience has taught us that housing stability is not a transaction — it is a relationship. And relationships require investment. Change 1 stands ready to serve as a thought partner and implementation resource for legislators, systems leaders, and policymakers committed to building housing infrastructure that actually works for youth.

YOUTH HOMELESSNESS PREVENTION REQUIRES A STABILIZATION ECOSYSTEM — NOT JUST HOUSING ACCESS.

Change 1 invites legislators, housing authority leaders, and systems partners to join us in building that ecosystem. We are prepared to provide technical assistance, share our model, and partner on solutions that move beyond the voucher and invest in the full stabilization continuum that youth aging out of foster care deserve.

Contact: www.change1.org | Location: Austin, Texas | Mission: Change One Mind. Change One Life.